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EXPLAINER

LA 2028, and USA Cricket's existential challenges

A contractual dispute between ACE and USA Cricket threatens the board's Olympic certification, its **standing with the ICC**, and its authority over the very game it is meant to govern.

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In 2019, USA Cricket handed over the keys to its future. American Cricket Enterprise Inc. (ACE), a private consortium co-founded by Sameer Mehta, Satyan Gajwani, Vijay Srinivasan, and Vineet Jain, secured exclusive 50-year rights to run elite T20 cricket in the United States of America. According to the Term Sheet signed between both parties, ACE promised to bankroll national teams, build six stadiums, and launch professional leagues that would make cricket America's next major sport.

On the field, that dream seems within reach. In 2024, the USA — an Associate Member of the ICC — co-hosted the ICC Men's T20 World Cup. The national team exceeded expectations by defeating Pakistan and advancing to the Super 8s. Recognising this achievement, USA Cricket was honoured with the ICC Associate Member Men's Team Performance of the Year award at the recently held ICC Annual

Conference in Singapore.

But off the field, the story has been far less harmonious. With the Olympics approaching and cricket newly added to the Los Angeles 2028 Summer Olympics (LA28) slate, that vision is fracturing.

A year ago, the ICC placed USA Cricket "on notice", and following the recent AGM, the global governing body reiterated: "The organisation remains on notice (USAC). USAC is required to undertake comprehensive governance reforms, including but not limited to completing free and fair elections within a three-month period."

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In a breach notice issued on June 23 this year, USA Cricket stated that ACE had violated major contractual terms: delayed payments, missing infrastructure deadlines, governance interference, and international

overreach. ACE, in turn, denied wrongdoing, claiming that USA Cricket had mischaracterised the Term Sheet and had failed to meet its own obligations.

Why this deal was always different

In most mature U.S. sports, national team governance is insulated from professional league control. Take basketball, for example. USA Basketball, a non-profit governing body, runs the Olympic programme, while the NBA's privately owned franchises manage the commercial league. The NBA does not own or fund USA Basketball; cooperation typically means player release and scheduling alignment, not a financial lifeline.

But USA Cricket's 2019 agreement flipped that script. ACE was granted sweeping control: full commercial rights, infrastructure responsibilities, and funding obligations for elite cricket — all in one bundled deal. In return, USA Cricket would receive a 5 per cent share of all cricket revenues and guaranteed minimum